response was typically unapologetic. ‘*Lagta hai een Congresswalon ko dar hai ki unki dukan bandh hone wali hai!’* (Looks like the Congress is upset that their shop is going to shut down.)

The strategy was clear—Modi was not here to play by the rules set by someone else; he wanted to create what Congress leader Jairam Ramesh later described as his own version of bodyline where unconventional attack was the best form of defence. If that meant disrupting an institutionalized practice and using even an Independence Day ceremony for political benefit, then so be it. Modi had positioned himself as the anti-establishment challenger to the old order. He wanted to assert his prime ministerial qualification and use his oratory as a weapon.

The contrast between the soft-spoken, monosyllabic Manmohan Singh and the punchline-a-minute, hard-hitting Modi was unmistakable. A bit like a Pujara vs Gayle battle in a T20 match. As a Modi aide remarked, ‘We were convinced that day that if we made this a presidential battle between a weak and a tough leader, then there could only be one winner.’ Modi was still not the BJP’s de jure prime ministerial candidate, but on 15 August, he became the de facto prime minister of his party, if not the country.

~

Modi was formally announced as the BJP’s prime ministerial nominee for the 2014 elections on 13 September 2013 amidst garlands and crackers at the party headquarters in Delhi. Typically, the announcement was accompanied by more drama and controversy. Advani refused to attend the parliamentary board meeting where the decision was taken. Instead, he chose to dash off another letter to Rajnath Singh, expressing his ‘anguish’ over the party president’s ‘style of functioning’. At the board meeting, Sushma Swaraj expressed her note of dissent, saying she was accepting the decision ‘under protest’.

The Advani–Sushma duo had a new rationale for their ‘rebellion’. Assembly elections in four crucial states of north India were due in a few months and it would be best to hold off any announcement till the elections